User Experience Audit

DONORS CHOOSE

https://www.donorschoose.org

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What is a UX Audit

A UX audit is a structured review of specific aspects of a website to identify usability issues and provide recommendations for how the design could be improved. It is for stakeholders, designers, and developers to all reference.

Why is it important?

Without a UX audit:

- Teams are left to rely on assumptions when making website improvements
- Inconsistencies diminish the user's experience
- Site output is not optimized for stakeholder value

What to expect

This audit provides a detlook a detailed look at how DonorsChoose performs across visual design, content, information architecture, accessibility, and heuristics.

The audit includes:
A heuristic evaluation using Nielsen's 10 usability principles
A WCAG accessibility rating covering screen reader, keyboard, and color contrast
A persona
A site map and user flow diagram
Page-specific findings for the Homepage, About us, Partner with us, and sub-navigation

Why *DonorsChoose*?

DonorsChoose connects donors to public school classrooms in need, making it one of the most trusted platforms for education funding in the United States.

The site already works well. With an established brand, and an effective user flow, focused improvements could make a good experience great.

About the auditor



I am a designer with a background in graphic design and social media marketing, currently studying Creative Technology and Design at the University of Colorado Boulder. My coursework includes ATLS 4720: User Experience Design 2, an advanced UX strategy course focused on research methodologies, prototyping practices, and the design of branded product experiences across global contexts.

Scope and objective

Scope

Key areas of focus:
Sub-navigation, visual design, information architecture and content, heuristic evaluation, and the flow from homepage to successfully placed donation.

Key pages reviewed:
Homepage, Find a Classroom, Partner with Us, About Us, and Help. These pages were selected for their high cognitive load, complex user flows, content density, and accessibility concerns.

Objective

DonorsChoose is a nonprofit platform connecting teachers in need of classroom resources with donors who want to support public education. This audit evaluates the site through the lens of its two primary users, teachers seeking donations and donors.

The objective is to identify opportunities to restructure the content, navigation, heuristics, and visual design so that teachers have the highest possible chance of receiving funding and donors experience the lowest possible cognitive load.

Evaluations

- Business Context
- Accessibility
- Persona
- Heuristics
- Visual Design / Content
- User Flow Map

Business Context

Product overview

DonorsChoose is a platform that connects public school teachers, schools, and classrooms with donors who want to support them. Teachers submit project requests, which can be physical products, one time donations, or recurring donations. The donor gets to choose what type of donation resonates with them the most.

Business goals

Maximize the number of donations, lower the barrier for teachers to create and share project requests, grow and retain an active donor base, expand corporate and foundation partnerships, and build trust through transparency in how donations are used.

Competitors

AdoptAClassroom.org, GoFundMe Charity, ClassWish, Amazon. DonorsChoose holds a strong position as the most recognized platform in the K-12 classroom donation space, which raises the stakes for the experience living up to that reputation.

User Demographic

Age range

Teachers range from **25–45**, with outliers of soon to be retirees. Donors have a wide range, from **young adults** making their first donation to **retirees** supporting local schools or grandkids. Most donors are **middle-aged professionals.**

Technical proficiency

With a wide age range of users, comes a wide range of technical ability. The site serves primarily middle aged professionals, with a decent amount but less young profesionals, or retirees. This leaves the technical ability at mostly **average, or above average**.

Geographic Location

Traffic is mostly **national**, with growing traffic from Nigeria and India.

Device type

According to *Similarweb* (Jan–Mar 2026), 56.30% of traffic arrives via **mobile** web.

Social breakdown

29% of social traffic originates from Nextdoor. This suggests teachers are sharing projects within their neighborhoods.

Community-motivated donors arrive with high emotional investment. This audience is mostly mobile and expects a fast, clear path to the project they would like to donate to.

Language and literacy level

The site is **English-only**, which is a notable gap given that many of the schools it serves are in multilingual communities. Literacy level varies significantly across the donor base, the site needs to communicate clearly to both limited and high digital literacy.

Visual Design

Typography

Fonts used:

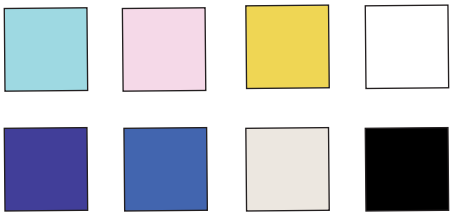
Proxima Nova - Extrabold

Proxima Nova - Semibold

Proxima Nova - Medium

- Headings, subheadings, and body text are easily distinguished
- Line spacing is effective
- No clashing type-faces.

Color



The palette has a wide range of colors that work surprisingly well. The contrast between text and background is strong.

Imagery and Iconography

Images are purposeful and on-brand. Photographs of smiling students and teachers reinforce the narrative without feeling staged. Accent imagery of school supplies adds personality and ties back to the classroom context. Images are web-optimized with no noticeable load lag, and decorative images include alt text. Icons are minimal and consistent in style; where present, they maintain high contrast and fit the visual language of the rest of the page.

Alignment

Elements are consistently center-aligned or left alignes with even spacing between components. Related content is effectively grouped using proximity, which makes the page feel organized rather than dense. Margins are generous and text never feels crowded against the edges.

Layout and Hierarchy

The layout has a clear grid with consistent side margins.
Information is organized with the most critical content at the top and least toward the bottom. Visual hierarchy is well-executed, larger colored headings draw the eye first, and lighter, smaller text communicates secondary importance effectively. Users can skim and orient themselves quickly without needing to read every word.

White space

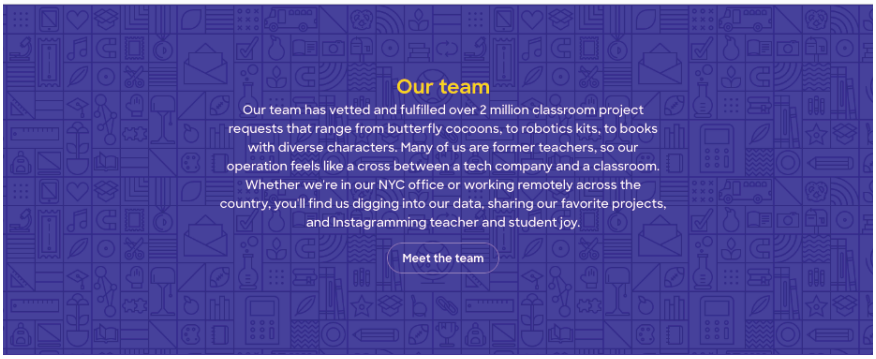
White space is one of the site's most effective design tools. Each section's padding is consistent around text blocks, and no section feels cluttered or overwhelming. The generous use of white space between content areas helps users process one idea at a time before moving to the next, which is especially important given the site's wide audience range. This is a clear strength to preserve in any redesign.

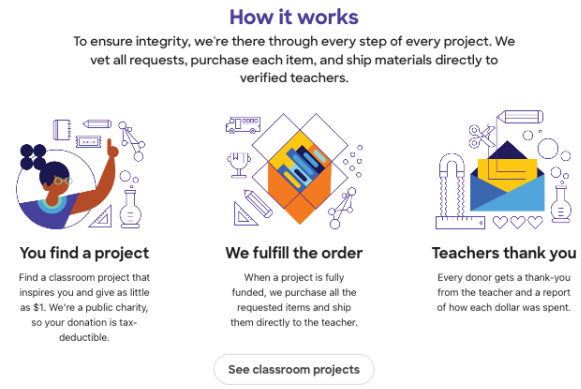
Responsive behavior

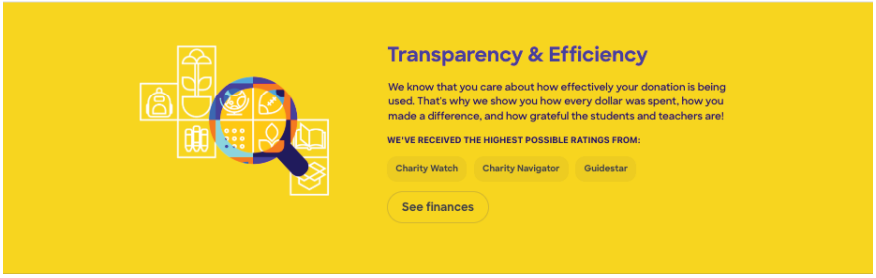
Pages are functional on mobile but the site is optimized for desktop.
Long vertical pages become especially taxing on smaller screens. The map feature in particular is difficult to use on mobile due to the z-position order issue identified in the accessibility evaluation.

Recommendations:

- Optimize the map feature for mobile by fixing the z-position issue
- Reduce vertical page length by simplifying content
- Keep existing strengths (white space, color contrast, typography)







Content

Voice and consistency

- DonorsChoose maintains a consistently upbeat, yet professional tone across all pages.
- Terminology is uniform, “sign in” is consistently used across the site, and formatting conventions are consistent throughout.
- The brand voice feels natural.

Help and documentation

- Empty states are handled well. When no search results are found, suggestions are offered.
- Micro-content such as progress indicators and form validation messages are present and functional.
- Navigation instructions between pages could be clearer.

CTA effectiveness

- CTA buttons are unclear where they lead, and many route users to pages that repeat content from elsewhere on the site.
- Only the browser’s back arrow can lead the user back to where they were.
- Labels like “Learn more” and “Tell me more” are used interchangeably for similar actions.

Recommendations:

- Clarify CTA Language so users can move through common paths without uncertainty
- Ensure CTAs route users forward rather than to pages that repeat content already read elsewhere
- Add back arrows so users can return without relying on the browser’s back arrow
- Standardize CTA wording instead of varying labels labels (“Learn more” vs “Tell me more”)

Heuristics

DonorsChoose was evaluated against Nielsen's 10 usability heuristics across the pages in scope. Each heuristic is rated as a pass, neutral, or fail, with severity assigned to all failures.

H1 — Visibility of system status — Pass

The site consistently signals what it's doing in response to user input. Hover states activate on CTA buttons, the map's search field shows a blinking cursor to indicate input is expected, dropdowns of suggested locations and products are present, and the Find a Classroom filters refresh results immediately on selection. Users can tell at every step that the system is registering their actions.

H2 — Match between system and the real world — Pass

Language follows familiar web language. "Sign in" appears consistently across the site, and section headers use plain language that signals what each page contains. Nothing requires users to learn specific vocabulary.

H3 — User control and freedom — Poor

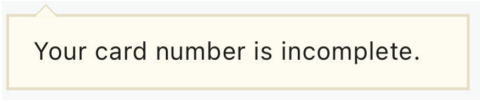
Users have limited ways to back out of actions or recover from navigation mistakes. There are no back buttons or arrows on internal pages, and only the browser back arrow is provided. Pop-ups have no close affordance, and users must infer that to leave the pop-up, they must click anywhere else on the screen.

The Help Center is the weakest in this area. Each topic opens to its own page with no nav or back arrow, so users must use the browser to return to the help index.

H4 — Consistency and standards — Pass

Visual elements are strong across the site. Color clearly distinguishes high vs. low priority content, font sizes establish a clear hierarchy between header and body text. Hover states are applied consistently sitewide.





H5 — Error prevention — Neutral

There isnt much room for error on the site, as most of the pages are just informational content, but there were 2 minor areas with issues:
- The Find a Classroom map filter allows multiple selections without specifying which combination pairs are valid
- Buttons open new tabs with no warning or way back.
- The Help page hides the main nav as soon as a user enters “How can we help you,”

H6 — Recognition rather than recall — Poor

Information is buried and hard to locate. Pages are accessible through the main nav, or through sub-navigation on ceritan pages. The user has no context for how they arrived on a page, or which page they are on. The user is forced to remember the steps that they have taken to get to a page. CTA buttons lead the user to one-of-a-kind pages that are difficult to relocate.

H7 — Flexibility and efficiency of use — Neutral

The site is approachable for new users, but the wording of the content supports users that appear to already be motivated to make a donation.

H8 — Aesthetic and minimalist design — Pass

The margins and alignment use white space effectively. Color pallette is bright, but not distracting. Font sizing is minimal, without being too small for visually impaired users.

H9 — Help users recognize, diagnose, and recover from errors — Pass

Error messaging is generally effective on the site. Where errors do appear, they tend to be clear: the map page expresses “No projects in this area, try another location or removing a filter” message when filters return no results, and the payment indicates, “Your card number is incomplete.”

The payment error confirms what is missing but doesn’t always explain why a transaction failed. The Find a Classroom filter lets users select combinations that silently conflict, with no message explaining the rules of the filters. Adding guidance on which filter combinations can be paired could repair the site’s error handling.

H10 — Help and documentation — Pass

Help is easy to find. Almost every component links to a supporting explainer page, and most pages include a local nav with FAQs or “What teachers say” sections that anticipate user questions. The volume and accessibility of documentation is a clear strength of the site — even where the help pages themselves have navigation issues (covered in H3 and H5).

Recommendations:

For User control (H3):
- Add in-page back arrows on internal pages
- Add close affordances (×) on all pop-ups
- Add back arrows or page headers on help page

For Recognition rather than recall (H6):
- Add dropdowns to the main nav so users can preview page contents
- Add page headers that match their name so users arent forced to remember

For Error prevention (H5):
- Clarify which Find a Classroom filter combinations can be used together before users select them
- Add small warnings before buttons that open new tabs or redirect off-site

Accessibility

WCAG Conformance

Screen reader

The screen reader is clear and logically ordered with almost no errors. Two minor issues were noted:
- a “skip to main content” link announced at the top of the page with no visible corresponding element on screen
- “status” markers appearing near input fields that did not lead anywhere or provide meaningful context.
- Nested links on some components, where the entire component is linked and a button inside it is also linked to the same destination. Screen reader users hear the same target announced twice, which slows navigation and creates redundant input.

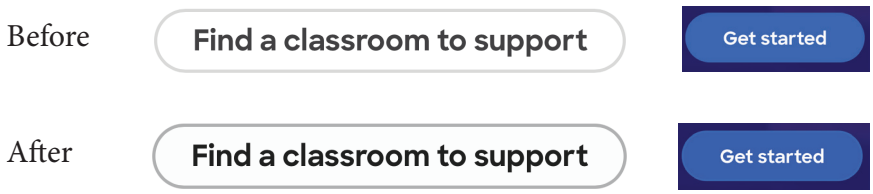
Keyboard navigation

All interactive elements were reachable via keyboard tab navigation and the focus indicator remained visible throughout.

Color contrast

The site generally performs well on color contrast. Most text and background combinations meet WCAG standards. The one failure identified was in the search input fields and button hover states, where light or dark backgrounds did not change enough on hover to indicate to visually impaired users that the button preforms an action.

Low contrast on hover states:



Recommendations:

- Strengthen hover state contrast on CTAs for visually impaired users
- Resolve nested links by removing the button link when the parent component is already linked
- Remove unused “status” markers

Persona

Maggie Holloway

70 · Retired elementary school librarian · Rural community



Maggie has lived in the same small town for 42 years. Her granddaughter Emma is in 4th grade at the local public school nearby. Emma mentioned that her class didn't have art supplies, which is what sparked Maggie to find a way to donate. She heard about DonorsChoose from a former volunteer of Emma's school.

Technical context

Above average for her age. Uses a laptop daily for email, news, video calls, and online shopping. Has donated online before. Reads page content rather than scanning.

Trust and confidence

Teacher testemonials, school names, and classroom-specfic product descriptions gove her the information that she needs.

Goals

- Donate directly to her granddaughter's classroom.
- Confirm her payment reached that specific project.
- Share the project link with her daughter and friends from church.

Constraints

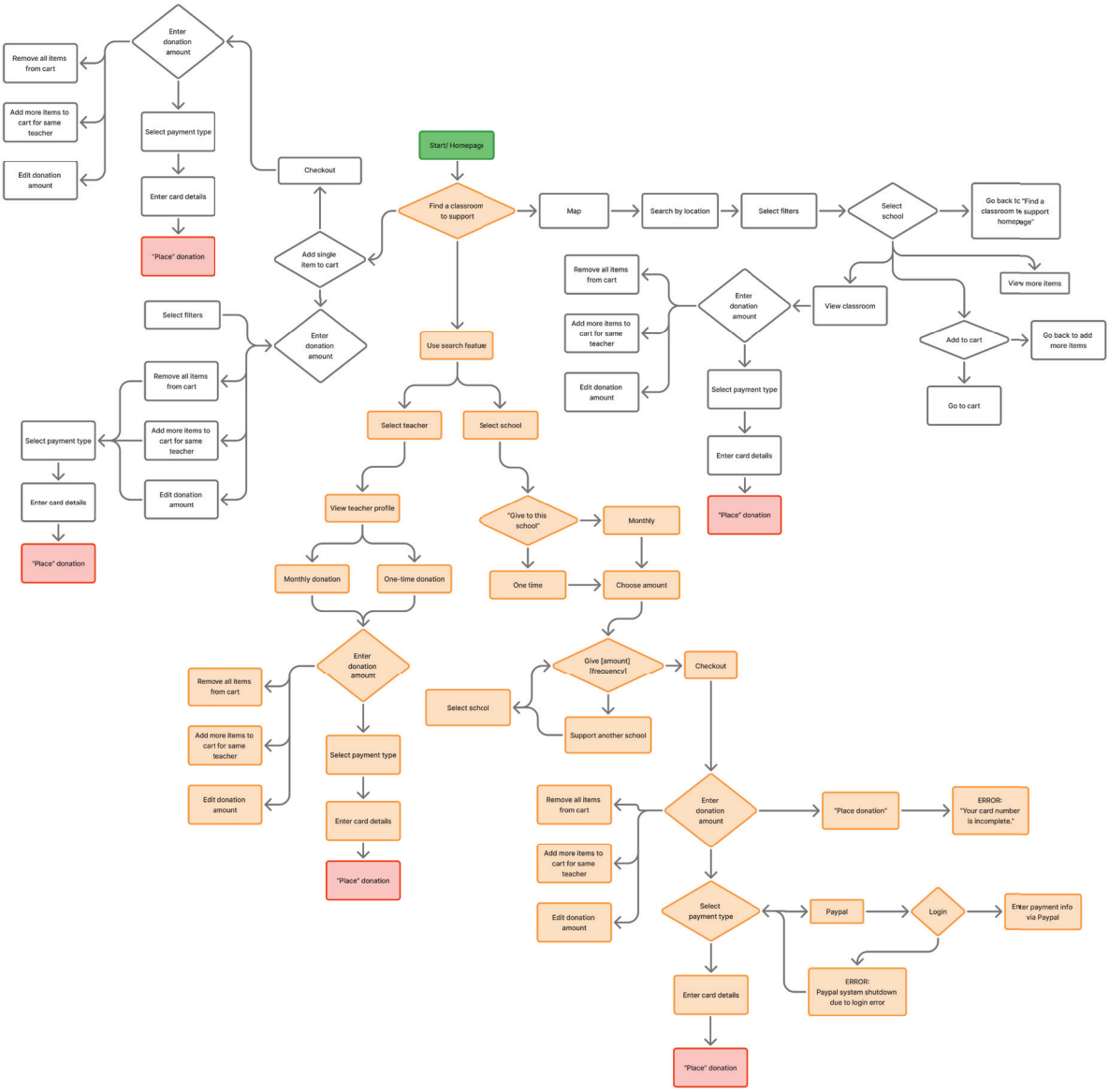
Vision — Wears reading glasses and browses at 125% zoom. Low-contrast hover states and small icons are hard to see
Memory — SLightly poor. If she can't remember how to return to a previous page, she restarts from the home page.
Pace — Reads rather than scans. Appreciates a variety of information.

Key barriers

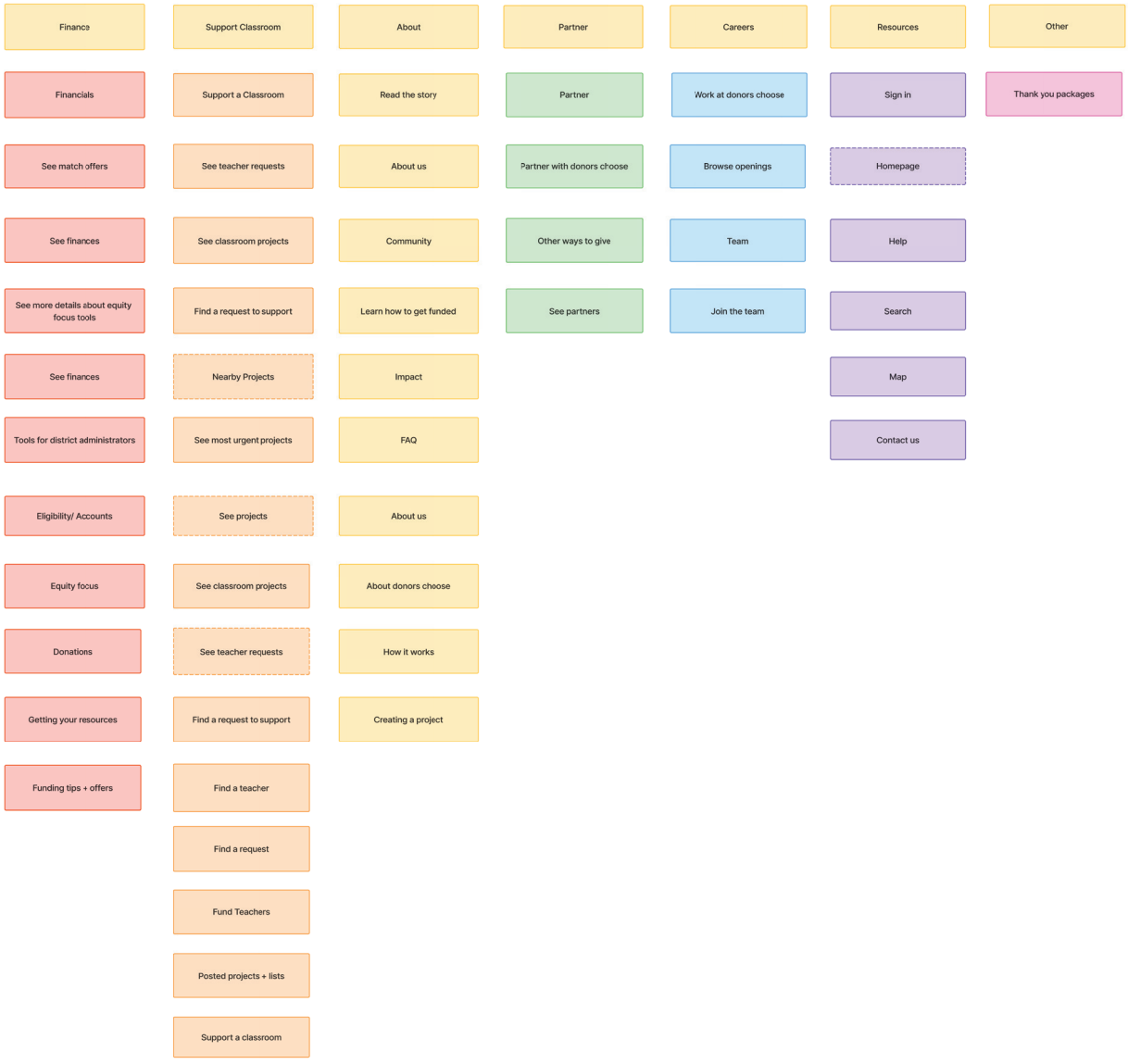
Maggie can make an educated guess to which page to choose, but must enter each page to find the type of information she is looking for. This is draining due to her declining memory.

User Flow Map

Donating to a specific classroom



Information Architecture



Findability

Several pages are reachable only through onf-off paths. “Give Monthly” is located at the bottom of the homepage rather than a more obvious spot. The Careers page is accessible only through one specific button and cannot be found else where. The Equity Focus area duplicates content already covered on the Find a Classroom page and the homepage, making it unclear which path a user should take to reach a specific donation type. Important pathways exist but require users to know where to have an intuitive understanding of where to go.

Content hierarchy

Most pages lack a header indicating which section of the site they are in. Once a user navigates past the homepage, there is no consistent visual cue of their location. Users frequently can’t tell what the most important content on a given page is, or whether they’ve already seen it elsewhere.

Labeling consistency

“Learn more” and “Tell me more” appear interchangeably for the same type of action. Filter labels on Find a Classroom use unclear language.

Wayfinding

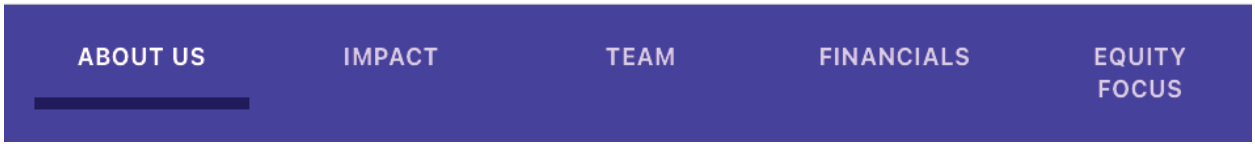
Several pages contain duplicated or near-duplicated content, making it difficult for users to remember which page had what information. Once a user lands on a dead end, there is no clear path back to the donation flow.

Navigation

The main navigation lacks dropdowns, so users must enter each section and read information to discover its contents. pages have no nav and no back arrow.

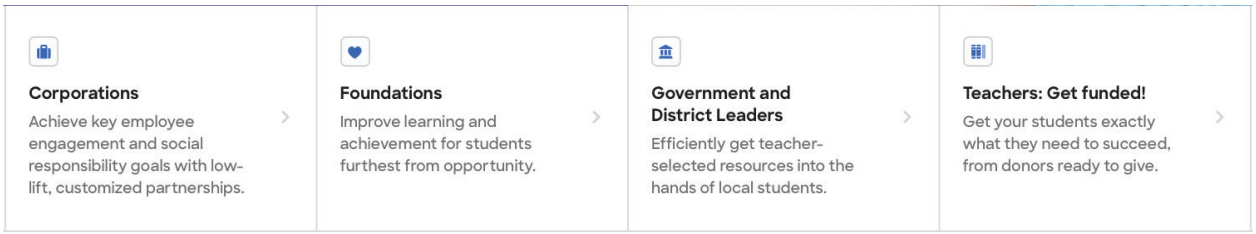
Subnavigation

About Us



The About Us page includes an internal nav bar leading to four sub-pages. The labels suggest separate content, but the pages content overlaps. The sub-nav doesn't indicate which page is currently being used, so once a user can look through multiple pages with no cue as to which one thay are on.

Partner with us



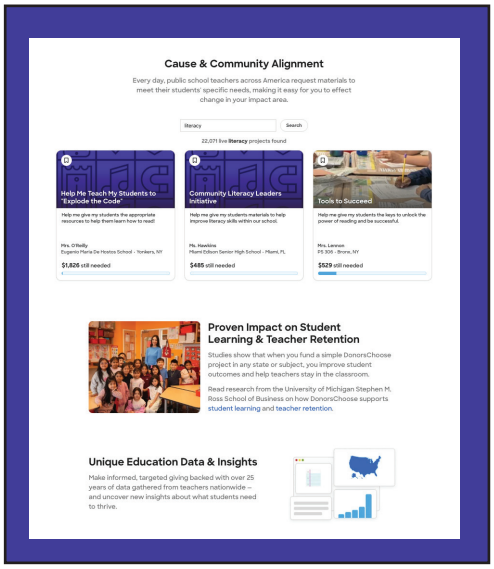
Partner with Us follows the same pattern. Its internal nav leads to sub-pages that contain content already covered on the parent page or elsewhere on the site. CTAs within these sub-pages lead users to more informational instead of moving them toward makling a donation.

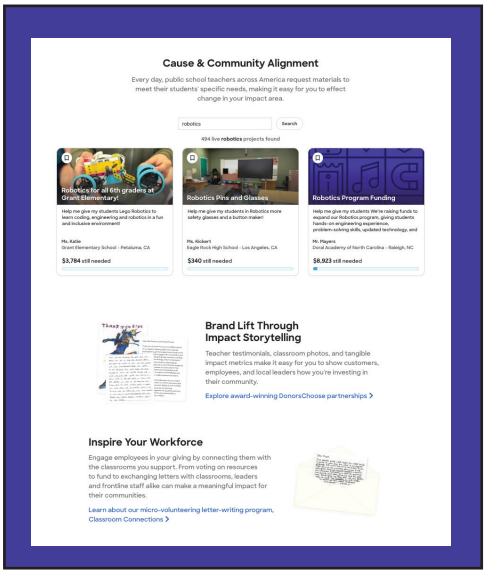
Found in varying layouts across the partner with us sub-navigation.





The only difference between the corporations page and the foundations page is these 2 small sections.





Reccomendations Overview

High priority

- Add dropdowns to the main navigation so users can preview section contents
- SImplify the four About sub-pages into a single drop down in the nav bar
- Merge the Foundations and Find a Classroom sub-page
- Eliminate redundant content on Partner with Us page
- Add back arrows on all internal pages so users aren't dependent on the browser back button
- Restore the main nav on the Help Center and all internal help topic pages
- Clarify Find a Classroom filter rules so users know which combinations work together.

Medium priority

- Move teacher testimonials and classroom stories higher on the homepage
- Standardize CTA labels — "Learn more" vs "Tell me more"
- Replace "highest economic need," "most donors" with simpler alternatives
- Strengthen hover state contrast on buttons
- Add page headers so users know where they are on the site
- Add close affordances (×) on all pop-ups
- Add a small confirmation before buttons that open new tabs

Lower priority

- Resolve nested links so screen readers don't repeat the same message twice
- Fix the z-position ordering issue (developers)
- Reduce vertical page length on long pages to improve mobile usability

Strengths



Variety of information

- Detailed teacher profiles
- FAQ sections throughout the site
- Empty states handled well, clear messaging when no results are found

Visual design

- Consistent white space and margins
- Strong color contrast on text
- Clear typographic hierarchy
- Cohesive color palette
- On-brand imagery of teachers and students
- Minimal icon style

Brand

- Warm, conversational tone
- Uniform terminology

Accessibility

- Most text and background combinations meet WCAG AA standards
- All interactive elements reachable via keyboard tab navigation
- Focus indicator remains visible throughout keyboard navigation
- Screen reader is clear and logically ordered with only minor issues

What we covered

Audit scope

Pages in scope: Homepage, Find a Classroom, About us, Partner with us, Help Center

Methods used

- Nielsen's 10 usability heuristics with pass / neutral / fail ratings
- WCAG accessibility evaluation including screen reader, keyboard navigation, and color contrast
- Donor persona
- User flow
- Traffic analysis sourced from Similarweb

Areas evaluated

- User demographics
- Visual design: typography, color, alignment, layout, white space, imagery
- Content: voice, consistency, help and documentation
- Information architecture: navigation, findability, content hierarchy, labeling, wayfinding
- Page-specific findings — Homepage, About us, Partner with us, Sub navigation

Thank you!